

City Routes

Chengdu → Chongqing:

Pandas, Hotpot & Mountains

(3-4 Days)

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The Sichuan Basin duo -- Chengdu and Chongqing -- are separated by just 1.5 hours on

China's newest high-speed rail line. Together they offer an irresistible combination:

Chengdu's laid-back teahouse culture and giant pandas, paired with Chongqing's

cyberpunk skyline and the world's spiciest hotpot. This 3-4 day route is perfect for food

lovers and adventure seekers.

Day 1-2: Chengdu -- Slow Living Capital

Day 1 Morning: Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding

(成都大熊猫繁育研究基地)

Arrive early -- gates open at 7:30 AM and the pandas are most active before 10 AM (after that, they're napping). The base houses 200+ pandas across different ages. The star attraction is the nursery where you can watch baby pandas tumbling over each other. Take the internal shuttle bus (¥10) to save 30 minutes of walking. The new "Panda Tower" viewing area offers elevated views of the enclosures. Book tickets online at least 2 days in advance via WeChat -- walk-in tickets are extremely limited.

07:30-18:00 | ¥55 | ! Book online in advance

Day 1 Afternoon: Jinli Ancient Street (锦里古街) & Wuhou Shrine (武侯祠)

Adjacent to each other, these two sites make a perfect afternoon pairing. Wuhou Shrine is a tranquil temple complex dedicated to Zhuge Liang (the legendary strategist from Romance of the Three Kingdoms). The red bamboo-lined paths and ancient cypress trees are hauntingly beautiful. Step outside into Jinli Ancient Street -- a 550m pedestrian

lane packed with Sichuan snack stalls, teahouses, and handicraft shops. Try the

three-shot tea (盖碗茶) performance and the Sichuan face-changing opera (变脸)

performers.

08:00-20:00 (Wuhou Shrine) / All day (Jinli) | ¥50 (Wuhou Shrine) / Free (Jinli)

Day 2 Morning: Kuanzhai Alley (宽窄巷子)

Three parallel alleys -- Wide Alley (宽巷子), Narrow Alley (窄巷子), and Well Alley (井巷子)

-- showcasing Qing Dynasty architecture with modern cafes, galleries, and teahouses.

This is the best place to try a traditional Sichuan ear-cleaning service (掏耳朵, ¥30-50)

from the ear-cleaning masters who've practiced for decades. Don't miss the Sichuan

Opera teahouse for a quick face-changing performance.

24/7 (outdoor area) | Free (entry)

Day 2 Afternoon: Sichuan Hotpot Experience

Chengdu is the birthplace of hotpot -- you can't leave without trying it.

Chen Mapo Tofu (陈麻婆豆腐)

on Xiyulong Street is the origin of the world-famous dish (est. 1862). For the full hotpot experience, head to

Shujiuxiang Hotpot (蜀九香)

or

Dalongyi Hotpot (大龙燚)

-- both are local institutions. Order the yuānyāng guō (鸳鸯锅, half spicy / half mild) if you can't handle full málà (麻辣, numbing-spicy). Dip beef tripe (毛肚, máodǔ) for exactly 15 seconds -- that's the rule.

11:00-21:30 | ¥40-70/person | Must-try: 麻婆豆腐, 宫保鸡丁, 回锅肉

Day 3-4: Chongqing -- Mountain City Madness

Getting There: HSR from Chengdu East to Chongqing North

The Chengdu-Chongqing HSR (成渝高铁) takes just 1 hour 15 minutes on the newest CR400AF trains. Second class tickets are ¥154. Trains depart every 15-20 minutes from Chengdu East Station (成都东站) -- no need to book far in advance. Arrive at Chongqing North Station (重庆北站), which connects to Metro Lines 3, 10, and the Ring Line.

Day 3: Hongya Cave (洪崖洞) & Jiefangbei (解放碑)

Hongya Cave is Chongqing's most iconic sight -- an 11-story stilted building complex clinging to a cliff face above the Jialing River, looking like a scene from *Spirited Away*.

Visit at sunset for the best photos as the golden hour light hits the traditional architecture. At night, the entire structure is illuminated in warm amber, reflecting off the river. The interior is a maze of restaurants, bars, and souvenir shops across multiple levels. Enter from the top (11th floor) and work your way down -- confusingly, you'll exit

at ground level on a completely different street. That's Chongqing for you.

All day (best at sunset/night) | Free

Day 4 Morning: Ciqikou Ancient Town (磁器口古镇)

A 1,000-year-old town on the banks of the Jialing River, Ciqikou is famous for its stilted houses (吊脚楼), mahjong parlors, and the best chén huā shēng (陈花生, spicy peanuts) in China. The main street gets packed on weekends -- explore the side alleys for hidden temples, teahouses, and the excellent Zhāng Fēi Niú Ròu (张飞牛肉, Zhang Fei Beef Jerky) shops. Don't leave without trying the má là xiǎo miàn (麻辣小面, spicy noodles) from the street stalls -- ¥8 for a bowl that will change your understanding of "spicy."

24/7 (outdoor area) | Free (entry)

Chongqing Hotpot: The Real Deal

Chongqing hotpot is different from Chengdu's -- it's more intense, more oily, and uses the jiǔgōng gé (九宫格, nine-grid pot) that divides the broth into nine sections, each with different heat levels. The tradition is to cook different ingredients in specific grids. Try

Pipa Yuan Hotpot (枇杷园火锅)

on Nanshan (South Mountain) -- the open-air mountain-top setting with city views is unforgettable. For city-center convenience,

Zhou Junma Hotpot (周师兄火锅)

near Jiefangbei is excellent.

11:00-02:00 | ¥80-120/person | Must-try: 九宫格锅底, 毛肚, 鸭肠, 酸梅汤

Route Tips

* Spice Survival:

* Sichuan food is legitimately numbing-spicy (麻辣). Order wēi là (微辣, mild spicy) or

yuānyāng (鸳鸯, half and half) to start. Keep sour plum drink (酸梅汤) and yogurt handy -- they neutralize the burn better than water.

* HSR Booking:

* Both cities have multiple stations. Use Chengdu East (成都东站) and Chongqing North (重庆北站) for the main HSR line. The newer Chengdu-Chongqing Middle Line (成渝中线) via the CR450 trains is even faster at 62 minutes.

* Budget Estimate:

* ¥2,000-3,500 per person for 4 days. Chengdu is slightly cheaper than Chongqing. Street food meals cost ¥15-30; restaurant dinners ¥60-120.

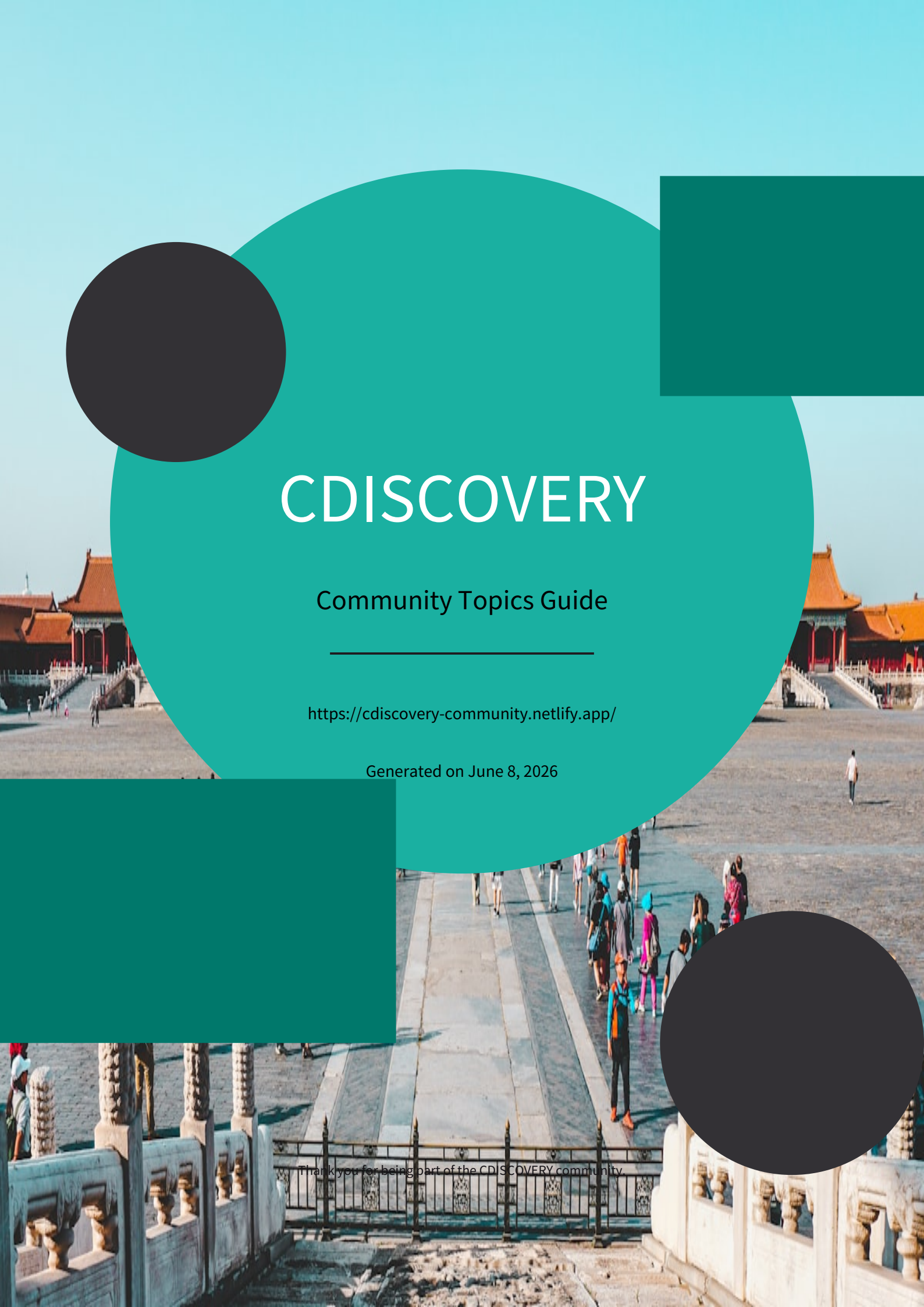
* Weather:

* Both cities are famously cloudy/foggy. Chongqing is called the "Fog Capital" -- embrace it. Summers are brutally hot (40 degC+). Best seasons: Spring (March-May) and Autumn (September-November).

* Getting Around:

* Both cities have excellent metro systems. In Chongqing, the metro literally goes through buildings -- Line 2 at Liziba station passes through a residential block. It's a tourist attraction in itself.

Sources: Sources: [China Conservation and Research Center for Giant Panda](https://www.panda.org.cn) • [12306 Official Railway](https://www.12306.cn) • [Chongqing Tourism](https://www.cqtpb.com)



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